

WEIMAR AND NAZI GERMANY, 1918–1939

KEY TOPIC 2: HITLER'S RISE TO POWER, 1919–1933

Student Master Textbook • Core Knowledge, Disciplinary Enquiries & Archival Evidence



Berlin, July 1931: Desperate crowds gathered outside the Sparkasse der Stadt Berlin during the Great Depression banking collapse (*Bankenkrach*). Historical Primary Photograph
The crash threw 6 million into unemployment and shattered faith in Weimar democracy.

OFFICIAL PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE SPECIFICATION STRUCTURE & SYLLABUS MAPPING (OPTION 31: KT2)

Core syllabus coverage across all four key enquiries:

1. EARLY NSDAP DEVELOPMENT, 1919–22

- DAP origins under Anton Drexler; Hitler joins and transforms party through personal oratory.
- The 25-Point Programme (Feb 1920): antisemitism, anti-Versailles, and pan-German nationalism.
- Formation of the SA (Brownshirts) under Ernst Röhm; party newspaper and the swastika emblem.

2. MUNICH PUTSCH & LEAN YEARS, 1923–29

- Munich Putsch (Nov 1923): causes, events at Bürgerbräukeller, and military collapse.
- Landsberg imprisonment: trial as propaganda triumph, writing of *Mein Kampf*, and legal strategy.
- Party reorganisation: Bamberg Conference (1926), SS creation, and electoral failure (2.6% in 1928).

3. GROWTH IN NAZI SUPPORT, 1929–32

- Wall Street Crash (Oct 1929): 6 million unemployed, bank collapses, and middle-class ruin.
- Death of parliamentary democracy: Chancellor Brüning cuts welfare and rules by Article 48.
- Growth of KPD; Nazi appeal to middle classes, big business, and youth via negative cohesion.

4. HOW HITLER BECAME CHANCELLOR, 1932–33

- Electoral breakthroughs: 107 seats (1930), 230 seats (July 1932); presidential elections.
- Fall of Brüning and Schleicher; Franz von Papen's aristocratic "Cabinet of Barons".
- The "Backstairs Plot": Papen convinces Hindenburg to appoint Hitler Chancellor (30 Jan 1933).

KT2.1: The Early Development of the Nazi Party, 1919–1922

Key Enquiry: From the shadows: How did a tiny, obscure political group in a Munich beer hall transform into a highly organised and violent political machine under Adolf Hitler's early leadership? • Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

ACT 1 THE ORIGINS: ANTON DREXLER, THE DAP & HITLER'S ORATORY

[1.1] The Foundation of the DAP & Hitler's Recruitment: In January 1919, in the turbulent aftermath of the First World War, railway mechanic Anton Drexler founded the German Workers' Party (*Deutsche Arbeiterpartei*, DAP) in Munich. Bitterly opposing the Weimar Republic, the Treaty of Versailles, and Marxism, Drexler advocated an extreme blend of pan-German nationalism and working-class protectionism. In September 1919, the Bavarian army dispatched intelligence agent Adolf Hitler to spy on a DAP beer hall meeting. Impressed by Hitler's fiery interjection in a political debate, Drexler recruited him as the party's 55th member, quickly appointing him director of propaganda.

[1.2] Hitler's Demagogic Star Power & Beer Hall Mass Rallies: Hitler rapidly transformed the obscure fringe group through theatrical public speaking. Rehearsing gestures and dramatic pauses, he began speeches in a quiet conversational tone before building to a crescendo of fanatical rage. He offered simple, visceral scapegoats for Germany's post-war collapse: the 'November Criminals', communist traitors, and international Jewish finance. Drawing thousands of paying spectators into Munich beer halls, Hitler raised vital admission revenues, winning fierce personal loyalty and making himself indispensable to the party's survival.

[1.3] Staging the Beer Hall Spectacle & The Bavarian Appeal: Hitler perfected the theatrical staging of party meetings. Arriving deliberately late to build tension, he entered large beer halls flanked by swastika flags, martial music, and armed stewards. In the smoke-filled halls of Munich, Hitler tapped into deep Bavarian grievances: hatred of the socialist republic in Berlin, outrage over the Versailles "war guilt" clause, and fears of a Bolshevik revolution. His impassioned delivery and radical anti-establishment stance transformed the DAP from a tiny tavern debating circle into a magnet for embittered veterans and extreme nationalists.

SOURCE A POLICE INTELLIGENCE REPORT

Munich, 15 February 1921

Bavarian Police Surveillance Report on Hitler's Early Speeches

"The speaker, Adolf Hitler, addressed an audience of over two thousand in the Bürgerbräukeller. He spoke with fanatical energy for two and a half hours, constantly whipping the crowd into frenzy over the 'November criminals', the Versailles treaty, and international Jewish finance... The applause was deafening. He possesses an extraordinary demagogic power over the uneducated masses."

Confidential Bavarian political police dossier assessing Hitler's rapid emergence as the primary public draw and propaganda chief for the fledgling NSDAP in Munich.

HINGE QUESTION: How does the police report explain Hitler's ability to transform a tiny fringe party into a mass movement in post-war Munich?

ACT 2 THE 25-POINT PROGRAMME, REBRANDING & THE SA (1920–1921)

[2.1] The 25-Point Programme & Party Rebranding: In February 1920, Hitler and Drexler unveiled the 25-Point Programme at the Hofbräuhaus beer hall before two thousand supporters. Designed as a populist manifesto to recruit across social classes, it blended nationalist demands (revoking Versailles, uniting all Germans in a Greater Reich, denying Jews citizenship) with socialist appeals (abolishing unearned income, profit-sharing in heavy industry, expanding pensions). In August 1920, Hitler rebranded the party as the National Socialist German Workers' Party (*NSDAP*), adopting the swastika emblem and the newspaper *Völkischer Beobachter*.

[2.2] The Führer Principle & Founding the Sturmabteilung (SA): By July 1921, Hitler used his oratorical indispensability to confront Drexler. Threatening to resign, he forced the committee to grant him absolute dictatorial powers as sole Party Chairman (*Führer*). In August 1921, he organized the *Sturmabteilung* (SA, or 'Brownshirts') under Ernst Röhm. Recruited largely from ex-soldiers and demobilised Freikorps fighters, the SA served as a violent paramilitary squad tasked with protecting Nazi speakers, assaulting rival communist rallies, and terrorising political opponents through disciplined street violence.

[2.3] The 1921 Führer Takeover & The Swastika Emblem: To consolidate total personal control, Hitler resigned in July 1921, demanding absolute dictatorial authority as Party Chairman (*Führer*). Realizing the party would collapse without his star appeal, the committee capitulated, granting him supreme leadership. Hitler introduced military discipline, the Roman arm salute, and designed the party banner: a black hooked cross (*Hakenkreuz*) on a white circle surrounded by revolutionary red. With the SA terrorising political rivals, the rebranded NSDAP stood ready to launch its bid for state power.

SOURCE B FOUNDATIONAL MANIFESTO

24 February 1920

Points 1, 2, and 4 of the Nazi 25-Point Programme

"1. We demand the unification of all Germans in the Greater Germany on the basis of the right of self-determination of peoples."

2. We demand equality of rights for the German people in respect to the other nations; revocation of the peace treaties of Versailles and St Germain."

4. None but members of the nation may be citizens of the state. None but those of German blood, whatever their creed, may be members of the nation. No Jew, therefore, may be a member of the nation."

Proclaimed by Adolf Hitler to over two thousand people at the Hofbräuhaus beer hall in Munich, establishing the core tenets of Nazi ideology: pan-German expansion, destruction of Versailles, and racial antisemitism.

HINGE QUESTION: Did the 25-Point Programme represent a coherent political ideology, or a contradictory collection of populist grievances designed to attract maximum support?

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 2.1

DAF	25-POINT PROGRAMME	STURMABTEILUNG (SA)	FÜHRERPRINZIP
German Workers' Party founded by Anton Drexler in 1919; renamed NSDAP (Nazi Party) under Hitler in 1920.	The founding political manifesto of the Nazi Party (Feb 1920) demanding revocation of Versailles and antisemitic citizenship.	The paramilitary "Brownshirts" formed in 1921 under Ernst Röhm to protect Nazi meetings and intimidate political rivals.	The "leader principle"; total dictatorial authority requiring absolute, unquestioning obedience from all subordinates.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

KT2.1: The Early Development of the Nazi Party, 1919–1922

ACT 3	BLOOD AND IRON: THE PARAMILITARY MUSCLE OF THE SA	ACT 4	HISTORICAL EVALUATION: A REGIONAL BAVARIAN FRINGE PARTY
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[3.1] Paramilitary Discipline & The Freikorps Recruits: Under the command of Captain Ernst Röhm, the *Sturmabteilung* (SA, or 'Brownshirts') underwent rapid expansion between 1921 and 1922. Recruited heavily from demobilized soldiers, unemployed youth, and violent Freikorps paramilitaries, the SA provided young men with military discipline, uniforms, free meals, and an outlet for violent anti-socialist hatred. By 1922, the SA operated as a private army of over 6,000 brawlers, marching in strict military formations and staging intimidating torchlight parades across Bavaria.

[4.1] Regional Containment & The Bavarian Sanctuary: While the creation of the 25-Point Programme and the *Völkischer Beobachter* demonstrated remarkable zeal, the early Nazi Party remained strictly confined to Bavaria. In the aftermath of the 1919 Bavarian Soviet Republic, Munich had become an ultra-conservative, anti-socialist sanctuary ruled by right-wing Commissioner Gustav von Kahr. Under Kahr's protection, the Bavarian police and judiciary turned a blind eye to right-wing violence, shielding the NSDAP from federal intervention and allowing Hitler to operate with impunity.

[3.2] Street Warfare & Intimidation as Political Theatre: The primary function of the SA was the violent monopolisation of public spaces. In November 1921, during the infamous 'Hofbräuhaus Battle', fifty SA stormtroopers assaulted hundreds of socialists attempting to disrupt a Hitler rally, beating them with beer mugs and table legs. However, recognizing that the SA retained strong personal loyalty to Röhm, Hitler established a dedicated personal bodyguard unit in 1923: the *Stosstrupp Adolf Hitler*, the forerunner of the SS. For Hitler, paramilitary violence was essential theatre: it created an aura of invincible power that appealed to Germans terrified of Bolshevik revolution.

[4.2] Bavarian Defiance & The 1922 Status: Following the June 1922 assassination of Foreign Minister Walther Rathenau, the Reichstag passed the Law for the Protection of the Republic, banning radical paramilitary groups. However, the Bavarian government openly defied Berlin, refusing to enforce the ban against the NSDAP. Despite having roughly 20,000 members and filling Munich beer halls, the NSDAP remained virtually unknown outside Bavaria. The party did not hold a single Reichstag seat, and industrial workers backed the SPD or KPD. Nevertheless, Hitler had built a disciplined machine that only awaited an economic crisis to break out nationally.

KEY CHRONOLOGY • FOUR CAUSAL TURNING POINTS			ENQUIRY 2.1 SEQUENCE
5 Jan 1919 • DAP Founded in Munich Anton Drexler forms the German Workers' Party; Hitler is dispatched by army intelligence and joins as member 55.	24 Feb 1920 • The 25-Point Programme Hitler announces the manifesto at the Hofbräuhaus, revoking Versailles and demanding a Greater German Reich.	29 Jul 1921 • Hitler Becomes Führer Hitler ousts Drexler, demanding absolute dictatorial control over the party; designs swastika emblem and banner.	Aug 1921 • Founding of the SA Ernst Röhm organizes the Brownshirts (*Sturmabteilung*), creating a private paramilitary army to control streets.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY • SECTION A

QUESTION 1 • 4 MARKS • 5 MINS

Exam Challenge: Give two things you can infer from Source A about the core beliefs of the Nazi Party in 1920. [4 marks]

Specification Technique: State 2 distinct historical inferences directly supported by explicit quotes or visual evidence from Source A.

GRADE 9 ACCURACY

KT2.2: The Munich Putsch and the Lean Years, 1923–1929

Key Enquiry: A spectacular failure or a political masterstroke: How did Hitler use the disaster of the Munich Putsch to completely rebuild the Nazi Party during its 'lean years'? • Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

ACT 1 THE CAUSES OF THE MUNICH PUTSCH (NOVEMBER 1923)

[1.1] By November 1923, the Weimar Republic appeared to be collapsing. French troops were occupying the Ruhr, hyperinflation had destroyed the currency, and the democratic government in Berlin looked entirely powerless.

[1.2] Hitler believed the time was right to strike, heavily inspired by the Italian fascist leader Benito Mussolini, who had successfully marched on Rome and seized power the year before. In Bavaria, the local right-wing government—led by the **Triumvirate** of Gustav von Kahr (Bavarian Prime Minister), Otto von Lossow (head of the Bavarian army), and Hans von Seisser (head of the Bavarian police)—was also actively plotting against the Weimar government. Hitler intended to hijack their plot, use their authority to take control of Munich, and then march his SA stormtroopers to Berlin to tear down the Republic.

[1.3] On the evening of **8 November 1923**, the Bavarian Triumvirate were speaking at a meeting in the Bürgerbräukeller (a large beer hall) in Munich. Hitler, backed by 600 armed SA members, burst through the doors. He fired a gunshot into the ceiling and declared a national revolution. At gunpoint, he forced Kahr, Lossow, and Seisser into a back room and made them swear loyalty to his uprising. Crucially, Hitler also had the backing of **General Erich Ludendorff**, a highly respected First World War military hero.

[1.4] However, the Putsch quickly unravelled. Hitler made a fatal error by leaving the beer hall to deal with a crisis elsewhere, allowing Ludendorff to let the Triumvirate go home. Once free, Kahr and Lossow immediately broke their promises and contacted the regular army and police to stop the Nazis.

[1.5] On **9 November**, Hitler and Ludendorff marched 2,000 Nazis into the centre of Munich. They were met by armed police. A brief, bloody firefight broke out. Fourteen Nazis and four policemen were killed. Hitler dislocated his shoulder, fled the scene, and was arrested two days later hiding in a wardrobe.

ACT 2 ADVANCED ANALYSIS: TURNING DISASTER INTO VICTORY

[2.1] On the surface, the Putsch was a humiliating failure. The Nazi Party was banned, and Hitler was put on trial for high treason. However, Hitler turned his trial into a political masterstroke.

[2.2] The trial gave Hitler national media coverage for the very first time. He used the courtroom as a theatrical stage, delivering passionate speeches arguing that he wasn't a traitor, but a patriot trying to save Germany from the "treasonous 'November Criminals'". The Weimar judiciary (judges) were traditionally very right-wing and sympathised with his hatred of the Republic. Instead of the death penalty (the standard punishment for treason), Hitler was given a remarkably lenient sentence of just five years in **Landsberg Prison**.

[2.3] In reality, he served only **nine months** in comfortable conditions. He spent this time dictating his manifesto, *Mein Kampf* (**My Struggle**). This book laid out his core beliefs, which would become the blueprint for Nazi Germany:

[2.4] * **Race:** The belief that the Germanic **Aryan** race was superior and destined to rule, while Jewish people were part of a global conspiracy plotting to weaken Germany. * **Lebensraum (Living Space):** The necessity of expanding Germany's borders into Eastern Europe and Russia to gain land and resources. * **Totalitarianism:** The destruction of democracy in favour of the **Führerprinzip** (the total authority of a single leader).

[2.5] **The Climax at the Feldherrnhalle:** On the morning of 9 November 1923, Hitler and Ludendorff led 2,000 armed stormtroopers through Munich toward the Bavarian War Ministry. At the narrow Residenzstrasse leading into the Odeonsplatz, a detachment of armed police opened fire. Sixteen Nazis and four police officers were killed within seconds. Göring was wounded, Hitler suffered a dislocated shoulder, and Ludendorff marched straight through the police line alone. Within hours, the putsch collapsed, and Hitler fled to Uffing where he was arrested two days later.

SOURCE A ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH

February 1924

Adolf Hitler, General Ludendorff, and Co-Defendants on Trial for Treason



Hitler and his fellow Munich Putsch conspirators photographed outside the Munich courtroom. General Ludendorff stands centrally in imperial uniform, while Hitler wears civilian dress with an Iron Cross, projecting patriotic legitimacy.

HINGE QUESTION: Why did the conservative Bavarian judges allow Hitler to turn a trial for armed treason into a nationwide nationalist propaganda showcase?

SOURCE B IDEOLOGICAL MANIFESTO

Landsberg Prison, 1924

Hitler on Political Struggle in *Mein Kampf*

"The receptive ability of the masses is very restricted, and their understanding feeble; on the other hand, they quickly forget. Such being the case, all effective propaganda must be confined to very few points and must harp on these in slogans until the last member of the public understands what you want him to understand... Blood mixing and the resultant drop in the racial level is the sole cause of the dying out of old cultures."

Written while serving his sentence in Landsberg Fortress, *Mein Kampf* combined extreme racial Social Darwinism with a cynical, highly calculated theory of mass political propaganda.

HINGE QUESTION: Did *Mein Kampf* provide a rigid masterplan for future Nazi policy, or merely reflect Hitler's raw ideological prejudices?

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 2.2

MUNICH PUTSCH (1923)

Failed armed coup launched by Hitler and Ludendorff on 8–9 Nov 1923 attempting to overthrow the Weimar government.

MEIN KAMPF

"My Struggle"; Hitler's autobiographical manifesto written in Landsberg Prison outlining Aryan supremacy and Lebensraum.

BAMBERG CONFERENCE (1926)

Party gathering where Hitler crushed the socialist wing led by Strasser and cemented absolute ideological control.

LEGAL STRATEGY

Hitler's post-putsch decision to abandon armed rebellion and win power legally by winning democratic elections.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

KT2.2: The Munich Putsch and the Lean Years, 1923–1929

ACT 3	THE WILDERNESS / LEAN YEARS (1924–1928)	ACT 4	ADVANCED ANALYSIS: THE BAMBERG CONFERENCE (1926)
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[3.1] While in prison, Hitler realised a crucial lesson: the Nazis could no longer try to seize power by force. They had to destroy democracy from the inside by winning elections—what he called the **"legal route"** to power: *"We shall have to hold our noses and enter the Reichstag."*

[3.2] Upon his release in December 1924, the ban on the Nazi Party was lifted, and Hitler set about drastically reorganising the political machine:

[3.3] **National Structure:** *He divided Germany into 35 local regions (Gau*), appointing a loyal Gauleiter to run each one and drive local recruitment.* * **The SS:** Because the SA was too rowdy and heavily loyal to Ernst Röhm, Hitler created the **SS (Schutzstaffel)** in 1925. Run by **Heinrich Himmler**, they wore black uniforms and acted as Hitler's fiercely loyal, elite personal bodyguards. **Targeting the Youth:** *In 1926, the party officially formed the **Hitler Youth** (Hitlerjugend*) to indoctrinate young boys, alongside the Nazi Women's League.*

[3.4] **Paramilitary Reorganisation: Founding the SS and Hitler Youth:** Following the Bamberg Conference of February 1926, Hitler consolidated his absolute authority. In 1925, he established the *Schutzstaffel* (SS) as an elite, fanatically obedient black-shirted personal bodyguard to counterbalance the unruly SA. In 1926, the party created the Hitler Youth (*Hitlerjugend*) to recruit teenage boys, alongside professional leagues for doctors, lawyers, and teachers. Recognizing the power of modern propaganda, Hitler appointed Dr Joseph Goebbels as Gauleiter of Berlin in 1926, tasking him with capturing the working-class capital through relentless provocation.

[4.1] As the party expanded nationally, a dangerous split emerged. The northern Gauleiters (like Gregor Strasser and Joseph Goebbels) wanted to focus heavily on the 'Socialist' parts of the 25-Point Programme to win over poor industrial workers. The southern Gauleiters wanted to focus on the 'Nationalist' parts to win over wealthy businessmen and the army.

[4.2] To prevent the party from fracturing, Hitler called the **Bamberg Conference** in 1926. He ruthlessly crushed the socialist wing of the party, asserting his absolute authority. Recognising talent, Hitler cleverly won over **Joseph Goebbels**, promoting him to Gauleiter of Berlin. Strasser was sidelined, and Hitler's total ideological dominance was secured.

[4.3] Despite having over 100,000 highly disciplined members by 1928, the Nazis were an electoral failure, winning just 12 seats (2.6% of the vote) in the 1928 Reichstag elections.

[4.4] The primary reason for this failure was Gustav Stresemann. The Weimar Republic was experiencing an economic 'Golden Age'. Hyperinflation was over, American Dawes Plan loans were flowing in, and in 1925, the German people had elected the conservative war hero Paul von Hindenburg as President. With the country feeling stable and proud, voters simply ignored the extreme politics of the Nazi Party.

[4.5] However, the Nazis were highly adaptable. Realising that industrial workers were voting for the Communists or Social Democrats, the Nazis shifted their propaganda. They began heavily targeting **farmers** (who were suffering from plummeting food prices) and the **lower-middle classes** (the *Mittelstand*, who had never recovered from hyperinflation). While they failed to win power in 1928, the Nazis had built a highly organised, national political machine just waiting for the next major crisis to strike.

KEY CHRONOLOGY • FOUR CAUSAL TURNING POINTS			ENQUIRY 2.2 SEQUENCE
8–9 Nov 1923 • The Munich Beer Hall Putsch Hitler hijacks Kahr's meeting and marches on Munich; police fire kills 16 Nazis and the coup collapses.	Feb–Apr 1924 • The Landsberg Trial Hitler turns his treason trial into a national propaganda triumph; sentenced to 5 years, serves only 9 months.	18 Jul 1925 • Publication of Mein Kampf Volume 1 of Hitler's manifesto is published, setting out racial hierarchy, anti-Semitism, and *Lebensraum*.	14 Feb 1926 • The Bamberg Conference Hitler re-establishes total authority over northern socialist rivals, cementing the unquestioned *Führerprinzip*.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY • SECTION A	QUESTION 2 • 12 MARKS • 18 MINS
Exam Challenge: Explain why the Nazi Party experienced the 'Lean Years' between 1924 and 1928. [12 marks]	
Specification Stimulus: (1) Stresemann's economic policies • (2) Hitler's reorganization of the party • Deploy 3 PEEL paragraphs with precise causal evidence.	
GRADE 9 CAUSATION	

KT2.3: The Growth of Nazi Support, 1929–1932

Key Enquiry: The shattered Republic: How did the economic earthquake of the Great Depression destroy Weimar democracy and propel Adolf Hitler from the political fringes to the brink of power? • Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

ACT 1 THE WALL STREET CRASH AND THE ECONOMIC EARTHQUAKE

[1.1] In October 1929, the US stock market collapsed, triggering the **Wall Street Crash**. Gustav Stresemann's warning that Germany was "dancing on a volcano" became a terrifying reality. Under the Dawes Plan of 1924, the German economy was entirely reliant on American loans. Following the crash, panicked American banks demanded their money back immediately.

[1.2] The economic impact on Germany was catastrophic. Without American investment, German factories were forced to shut down. By 1932, unemployment had reached a staggering **6 million** (roughly 40% of the German workforce). Millions were left homeless, relying on soup kitchens and sleeping in parks. Crucially, the middle classes—who had already lost their savings during the 1923 hyperinflation crisis—found themselves facing ruin once again as businesses and banks collapsed.

[1.3] **The Banking Crisis & Industrial Collapse:** The disaster deepened in 1931 when Austria's Creditanstalt and Germany's Danat Bank failed, forcing Chancellor Brüning to declare a nationwide bank holiday. Over 50,000 German businesses went bankrupt between 1930 and 1932. Industrial production plunged by 42%, while middle-class savers saw their deposits frozen once again. Desperate families lined the streets of major cities, where over 600,000 people were registered homeless.

[1.4] **The Human Cost: Shantytowns, Breadlines and Social Despair:** By 1932, over 6 million Germans were officially registered as unemployed, though real numbers exceeded 8 million when uncounted women and youths were included. In Berlin, thousands of evicted families lived in squalid shantytowns named 'Tent Cities' (*Zeltstädte*). Impoverished war veterans and fathers queued for hours outside municipal soup kitchens, wearing cardboard placards that read: "I will take any work, even the hardest." This pervasive poverty shattered faith in democracy.

SOURCE A ELECTION PROPAGANDA POSTER 1932 Presidential Election

Our Last Hope: Hitler (Unsere letzte Hoffnung: Hitler)



Designed by artist Mjölner (Hans Schweitzer) for the 1932 elections, showing grim, impoverished faces of unemployed workers, mothers, and veterans looking up toward Hitler as their solitary saviour from economic ruin.

HINGE QUESTION: Why was this visual imagery extraordinarily effective at winning over voters who had never previously supported extreme nationalism?

ACT 2 THE DEATH OF DEMOCRACY: MÜLLER AND BRÜNING

[2.1] As the economic crisis deepened, the Weimar political system completely paralysed. The Chancellor, a Social Democrat named **Hermann Müller**, led a 'Grand Coalition' of moderate parties. However, as unemployment skyrocketed, the politicians bitterly argued over whether to raise taxes or cut unemployment benefits. Unable to agree, Müller resigned in March 1930. This marked the end of truly democratic government in Weimar Germany.

[2.2] He was replaced by **Heinrich Brüning**. Because Brüning could not get a majority in the Reichstag, he relied on President Hindenburg to pass laws using **Article 48** (emergency decrees).

[2.3] **Advanced Analysis: The 'Hunger Chancellor'** Brüning's response to the crisis was disastrous. Fearing a repeat of the 1923 hyperinflation, he refused to print more money. Instead, he raised taxes, slashed government wages, and cut unemployment benefits. This caused immense suffering, earning him the bitter nickname the **'Hunger Chancellor'**. With the moderate government actively making the people poorer and bypassing parliament, desperate Germans began to abandon democracy entirely and vote for extreme parties who promised radical solutions.

[2.4] The first group to benefit from this desperation was the **KPD (Communist Party)**. Unemployed, starving industrial workers flocked to the KPD, which promised to overthrow the wealthy industrialists and share the nation's wealth equally. By 1932, the KPD had gained 100 seats in the Reichstag.

[2.5] However, this surge in communist support terrified the German middle classes, rural farmers, and wealthy business owners. Rich industrialists like **Fritz Thyssen**, the Krupp family, and Bosch were terrified of a Russian-style revolution where their factories would be confiscated. Consequently, they began secretly pouring millions of marks into the Nazi Party, viewing Hitler as their best defence against the Communists. This massive financial backing allowed Joseph Goebbels to fund an unparalleled propaganda campaign.

SOURCE B OFFICIAL STATISTICAL RECORD

Statistical Office of the German Reich

Reichstag Election Results & German Unemployment (1928–1932)

*"May 1928: 1.4 million unemployed • Nazi vote: 2.6% (12 seats)
September 1930: 3.0 million unemployed • Nazi vote: 18.3% (107 seats)
July 1932: 5.4 million unemployed • Nazi vote: 37.3% (230 seats)
November 1932: 5.1 million unemployed • Nazi vote: 33.1% (196 seats)
Communist (KPD) vote surged concurrently from 54 seats in 1928 to 100 seats in November 1932."*

Official Reich statistics demonstrating the direct mathematical correlation between rising unemployment following the Wall Street Crash and the dramatic electoral surge of extremist parties.

HINGE QUESTION: Does the November 1932 decline in Nazi votes demonstrate that the party had already passed its electoral peak before Hitler became Chancellor?

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 2.3

WALL STREET CRASH (1929)

Catastrophic US stock market collapse in October 1929, triggering the global Great Depression and German economic ruin.

HEINRICH BRÜNING

Weimar Chancellor (1930–32) whose deflationary wage and benefit cuts earned him the label "the Hunger Chancellor".

NEGATIVE COHESION

Voters uniting around shared hatreds (fear of communism, disgust with Weimar) rather than agreement on Nazi policies.

KPD

The German Communist Party, whose surging support terrified middle-class Germans and drove them toward the Nazis.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

ACT 3THE APPEAL OF HITLER AND NAZI PROPAGANDA

ACT 4ADVANCED ANALYSIS: THE SA AND NEGATIVE COHESION

[3.1] Using this new wealth, the Nazis presented themselves as the only political force strong enough to save Germany.

[3.2] *The 1932 Presidential Election:* Hitler challenged the ageing Hindenburg for the presidency. Although Hitler lost, he won an astonishing **13.4 million votes**. This campaign catapulted him to national superstar status. He was the first politician to fly by aeroplane to multiple cities in a single day (the "Hitler over Germany"* campaign), giving him the image of a dynamic, energetic saviour. *Targeted Propaganda:* Nazi propaganda was highly sophisticated. If an anti-Semitic poster didn't work in a certain town, they quietly dropped it and used a poster promising higher crop prices for farmers instead. They promised 'Work and Bread'* to the unemployed. * **Appealing to Demographics:** They successfully targeted **women** by claiming that voting for the Nazis was the best way to protect traditional family values and save their children from starvation. They targeted **young people** by portraying the Weimar Republic as weak and elderly, and the Nazi movement as exciting and rebellious.

[4.1] The growth of the Nazi Party was not just about brilliant posters; it was deeply rooted in violence and **negative cohesion**.

[4.2] By 1932, the SA had grown to 400,000 members. Germany's streets were erupting into open warfare as the SA fought brutal battles against the communist private army, the *Rotfrontkämpferbund*. Dozens of people were killed in political street fights.

[4.3] Paradoxically, the Nazis used this violence to their advantage. They deliberately started the fights with the communists, but then used their highly disciplined, uniformed SA marches to present themselves to the middle classes as the only party capable of restoring order. Millions of middle-class voters ultimately voted for the Nazis not because they fully supported Hitler's extreme racial views, but because of *negative cohesion*—they shared Hitler's hatred of the Weimar Republic and his absolute determination to crush the communists.

KEY CHRONOLOGY • FOUR CAUSAL TURNING POINTS

ENQUIRY 2.3 SEQUENCE

24 Oct 1929 • The Wall Street Crash US banks call in short-term loans; German factories close, banks fail, and mass unemployment begins to surge.	14 Sep 1930 • Reichstag Breakthrough Nazis leap from 12 to 107 seats, becoming the second-largest party as Brüning imposes deflationary austerity.	Apr 1932 • Presidential Election Hitler wins 13.4 million votes (36.8%) against Hindenburg, proving massive national support via plane campaign.	31 Jul 1932 • Largest Party in Reichstag NSDAP wins 230 seats (37.3%) amid 6 million unemployed; Hindenburg refuses to make Hitler Chancellor.
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EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY • SECTION B

QUESTION 3(a) • 8 MARKS • 12 MINS

Exam Challenge: How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into the reasons for the growth of Nazi support in the years 1929–1932? [8 marks]

Specification Technique: Interrogate Content, Provenance (Nature, Origin, Purpose), and Context for both sources before reaching a weighed judgment.

GRADE 9 UTILITY

KT2.4: How Hitler Became Chancellor, 1932–1933

Key Enquiry: The Backstairs Intrigue: How did secret political scheming, revenge, and a fatal underestimation rescue a struggling Adolf Hitler and hand him the Chancellorship of Germany? • Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

ACT 1 THE FALL OF BRÜNING, ECONOMIC DESPAIR & THE DEATH OF DEMOCRACY

[1.1] Brüning's Austerity & The Collapse of Parliamentary Rule: By the spring of 1932, parliamentary democracy in Weimar Germany had completely collapsed. Unable to maintain a coalition majority in the Reichstag, Chancellor Heinrich Brüning relied entirely on President Paul von Hindenburg to govern through Article 48 emergency decrees. Brüning's relentless deflationary austerity—slashing unemployment benefits, cutting civil service wages, and raising taxes—worsened the Great Depression, driving unemployment past 6 million and earning him the bitter title of the 'Hunger Chancellor'.

[1.2] The Ban on the SA and the Fatal Agrarian Miscalculation: In April 1932, attempting to quell escalating street warfare, Brüning banned the SA and SS, provoking outrage from right-wing nationalists and conservative army generals led by Kurt von Schleicher. Simultaneously, Brüning proposed breaking up bankrupt aristocratic estates in East Prussia to settle unemployed workers. Hindenburg, himself a wealthy Junker landlord, was outraged by this plan, condemning it as "agrarian Bolshevism". Betrayed by Schleicher and abandoned by the President, Brüning was forced to resign on 30 May 1932.

[1.3] The Preussenschlag & The Summer of Paramilitary Terror: The lifting of the SA ban in June 1932 triggered widespread political violence, resulting in over 100 street murders in five weeks. In Hamburg, the 'Altona Bloody Sunday' left 18 dead. Papen cynically exploited this disorder to execute the *Preussenschlag* (Prussian coup), declaring martial law and unconstitutionally removing the democratically elected SPD state government of Prussia. By dismantling Prussia's independent police force, Papen destroyed the strongest remaining democratic bulwark against National Socialism.

SOURCE A ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH

21 March 1933

Vice-Chancellor Franz von Papen and Chancellor Adolf Hitler on Potsdam Day



Vice-Chancellor Franz von Papen walking in top hat and tails alongside newly appointed Chancellor Adolf Hitler outside the Potsdam Garrison Church. Papen famously reassured conservative allies: "We have hired him for our own purposes... In two months' time, we will have pushed Hitler so far into a corner that he'll squeak!"

HINGE QUESTION: How does this photograph and Papen's private boast demonstrate the fatal miscalculation of Germany's traditional conservative elites?

ACT 2 THE 1932 ELECTIONS & THE BACKSTAIRS INTRIGUE

[2.1] The 'Cabinet of Barons' and the July 1932 Electoral Triumph: Hindenburg appointed conservative aristocrat Franz von Papen as Chancellor, heading an unelected aristocratic ministry nicknamed the 'Cabinet of Barons'. Lacking Reichstag support, Papen lifted the ban on the SA and dissolved parliament to hold fresh elections in July 1932. The election was a stunning triumph for the NSDAP: winning 230 seats (37.3% of the vote), the Nazis became the largest party in the Reichstag. Hitler immediately demanded the Chancellorship. However, President Hindenburg, deeply contemptuous of the Austrian-born "Bohemian corporal", flatly refused.

[2.2] The November 1932 Crisis & Papen's Fatal Deal: Refusing to cooperate, the Nazis and Communists paralysed parliament, forcing another election in November 1932. Nazi support dropped to 196 seats, while communist votes surged. Terrified of civil war, General Schleicher persuaded Hindenburg to sack Papen and make Schleicher Chancellor in December. Determined to seek revenge, Papen struck a secret deal with Hitler in January 1933: Hitler would become Chancellor in a coalition cabinet where only three of eleven ministers were Nazis, with Papen as Vice-Chancellor with personal right of access to Hindenburg. Papen boastfully assured traditional conservatives: "Within two months, we will have pushed Hitler so far into a corner that he'll squeak!" On 30 January 1933, Hindenburg appointed Adolf Hitler Chancellor of Germany.

[2.3] The Cologne Villa Deal & Schleicher's Humiliation: General Schleicher's tenure as Chancellor was brief and disastrous: his attempts to split the Nazi party by offering Gregor Strasser the Vice-Chancellorship collapsed, alienating both Hitler and trade unions. Meanwhile, Papen met Hitler secretly on 4 January 1933 at the Cologne villa of banker Kurt von Schröder. Backed by wealthy industrialists and Hindenburg's inner circle (including the President's son Oskar), Papen persuaded Hindenburg that Hitler could be tightly controlled in a cabinet with only two other Nazis (Göring and Frick), sealing the fate of the Republic.

SOURCE B PRESIDENTIAL STATEMENT

13 August 1932

President Paul von Hindenburg to Adolf Hitler

"His Excellency the Reich President declared that he could not reconcile it with his conscience and his duties to the Fatherland to transfer the entire governing power to the National Socialist movement alone, which wished to use this power in a one-sided manner. He regretted that Herr Hitler saw himself unable to support a national government headed by Chancellor von Papen."

Hindenburg's frosty rejection of Hitler's demand for the Chancellorship following the July 1932 elections, highlighting the 84-year-old Field Marshal's deep aristocratic contempt for the Austrian-born "Bohemian corporal".

HINGE QUESTION: What factors forced President Hindenburg to reverse his vehement refusal and appoint Hitler Chancellor just five months later?

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 2.4

BACKSTAIRS INTRIGUE

Secret aristocratic negotiations between Papen, Schleicher, and Hindenburg to bypass the Reichstag and appoint Hitler.

FRANZ VON PAPEN

Conservative aristocrat who persuaded Hindenburg to appoint Hitler Chancellor, falsely believing he could control him.

KURT VON SCHLEICHER

Army general and Chancellor (Dec 1932–Jan 1933) whose failed intrigue against Papen paved the way for Hitler's appointment.

30 JANUARY 1933

The date Adolf Hitler was formally sworn in as Chancellor of Germany by President Paul von Hindenburg.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

KT2.4: How Hitler Became Chancellor, 1932–1933

ACT 3	SCHLEICHER'S FAILURE AND THE 'BACKSTAIRS PLOT' (DEC 1932 - JAN 1933)	ACT 4	ADVANCED ANALYSIS: THE FATAL MISCALCULATION
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[3.1] Fearing that keeping Papen in power would cause the SA to start a civil war, Hindenburg sacked Papen and reluctantly made General **Kurt von Schleicher** Chancellor in December 1932.

[3.2] Schleicher's time as Chancellor was a complete failure. He had no political support and could not control the Reichstag. Meanwhile, a furious and humiliated Franz von Papen wanted revenge against Schleicher.

[3.3] Papen began a '**backstairs intrigue**'—secretly meeting with Adolf Hitler, alongside members of Hindenburg's **camarilla** (his son Oskar von Hindenburg and advisor Otto von Meißner). They struck a backroom deal: if Papen could convince the ageing President to make Hitler Chancellor, Hitler would make Papen Vice-Chancellor.

[4.1] On **30 January 1933**, President Hindenburg officially appointed Adolf Hitler as Chancellor of Germany.

[4.2] To a modern historian, it seems unbelievable that the conservative elites would hand power to a violent extremist. However, they believed they had trapped Hitler in a political cage. Out of a Cabinet of 12 ministers, Hindenburg and Papen allowed **only two other Nazis** (Wilhelm Frick and Hermann Göring); the rest were traditional conservatives.

[4.3] The elites severely underestimated Hitler, viewing him as an uneducated political amateur they could easily manipulate to crush the communists. Papen famously boasted to a friend: "*We have framed him... in two months we will have pushed Hitler into a corner so hard that he'll be squeaking.*" They believed they were hiring Hitler as their puppet; in reality, they had just handed him the keys to the Republic.

KEY CHRONOLOGY • FOUR CAUSAL TURNING POINTS

ENQUIRY 2.4 SEQUENCE

30 May 1932 • Brüning Sacked by Hindenburg Hindenburg dismisses Brüning over East Prussian land reforms; appoints Franz von Papen to lead the "Barons".	6 Nov 1932 • Nazi Electoral Setback NSDAP loses 34 seats and party funds run dry; General von Schleicher replaces Papen as Chancellor in December.	4 Jan 1933 • Cologne Villa Conspiracy Papen meets Hitler secretly at banker Schröder's villa, plotting to oust Schleicher by offering Hitler power.	30 Jan 1933 • Hitler Appointed Chancellor Hindenburg appoints Hitler Chancellor in an 11-man cabinet with only 3 Nazis; Papen claims Hitler is "boxed in".
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EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY • SECTION B

QUESTION 3(d) • 16 MARKS + 4 SPaG • 25 MINS

Exam Challenge: How far do you agree with Interpretation 2 about how Hitler became Chancellor in 1932–33? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. [16 marks]

Specification Technique: Weigh Interpretation 1 against Interpretation 2; deploy precise contextual evidence; sustain a criteria-led historical verdict.

GRADE 9
VERDICT

KEY TOPIC 2 REVISION SPINE: CORE KNOWLEDGE & EXAM STRATEGY

Pearson Edexcel GCSE (9–1) History • Paper 3 Option 31 (1H10/31)

1. KEY CHRONOLOGY • CAUSAL TURNING POINTS

KEY CHRONOLOGY

5 Jan 1919: DAP Founded in Munich: Anton Drexler establishes party; Hitler joins as military intelligence agent in Sep 1919.	24 Feb 1920: 25-Point Programme: Hitler proclaims manifesto at Hofbräuhaus; party renamed National Socialist (NSDAP).	29 Jul 1921: Hitler Becomes Führer: Hitler ousts Drexler, demanding absolute dictatorial control over party organization.
4 Nov 1921: SA Officially Established: Ernst Röhm organizes Brownshirt paramilitary squad to intimidate political opponents.	8–9 Nov 1923: The Munich Putsch: Hitler attempts armed coup in Bavaria; 16 Nazis killed at Feldherrnhalle; Hitler jailed.	Feb–Dec 1924: Landsberg Imprisonment: Hitler turns trial into propaganda triumph; writes <i>Mein Kampf</i> ; adopts legal strategy.
14 Feb 1926: Bamberg Party Conference: Hitler defeats northern socialist faction (Goebbels/Strasser); reasserts Führerprinzip.	20 May 1928: Reichstag Election Failure: Golden Twenties prosperity reduces Nazi vote to just 2.6% (12 seats) nationally.	29 Oct 1929: Wall Street Crash: US banks recall short-term loans; German factories close; unemployment surges toward 6M.
14 Sep 1930: Reichstag Breakthrough: Amid economic panic, Nazi vote surges eightfold to 18.3% (107 seats), becoming 2nd largest party.	31 Jul 1932: Peak Nazi Electoral Triumph: Nazis win 37.3% (230 seats) to become largest party; Hindenburg refuses Hitler Chancellorship.	30 Jan 1933: Hitler Appointed Chancellor: Papen and Hindenburg agree backstairs deal, mistakenly believing they can control Hitler.

2. CORE SPECIFICATION THEMES

SPECIFICATION REVIEW

I. EARLY IDEOLOGY & PARAMILITARY VIOLENCE The 25-Point Programme fused militant nationalism, anti-Versailles revanchism, and racial antisemitism. Ernst Röhm's SA provided street-level muscle, violently silencing political opponents and creating an image of dynamic militarism.	II. THE MUNICH PUTSCH & LEGAL STRATEGY The 1923 coup failure proved the state could not be seized by force. In Landsberg Prison, Hitler formulated the legal strategy: utilizing democratic elections to dismantle democracy from within, while building a nationwide Gauleiter network.	III. GREAT DEPRESSION & MASS MOBILISATION The Wall Street Crash wiped out 6 million jobs. Heinrich Brüning's austerity dismantled parliamentary rule. Hitler capitalized on "negative cohesion"—uniting frightened middle-class voters terrified of a communist Bolshevik revolution.	IV. CONSERVATIVE BACKSTAIRS INTRIGUE Despite losing 2 million votes in November 1932, Hitler was handed power by Franz von Papen and conservative elites. Their arrogant delusion that they could "box Hitler into a corner" was the fatal catalyst that destroyed the Republic.
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3. HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE & EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY

EXAM STRATEGY • Q3(B,C,D)

INTERPRETATION 1: THE MASTER DEMAGOGUE (ALAN BULLOCK) Hitler was an unprincipled political opportunist of genius who combined theatrical oratory, ruthless tactical flexibility, and cynical exploitation of German grievances to manipulate both the masses and conservative elites into giving him power.		INTERPRETATION 2: CIRCUMSTANCE & CHARISMATIC MOBILISATION (IAN KERSHAW) Hitler was not an all-powerful puppet master. His rise was made possible because the Great Depression created a total systemic collapse of Weimar institutions, allowing his radical message to resonate with millions seeking salvation.		
Q1: INFERENCE [4m] 5 Mins • 2 Inferences + Quotes	Q2: CAUSATION [12m] 15 Mins • 3 PEEL Causal Factors	Q3(a): UTILITY [8m] 12 Mins • Content, NOP & Context	Q3(b/c): VIEWS [8m] 10 Mins • Differences & Reasons	Q3(d): VERDICT [16+4m] 25 Mins • Balanced Evaluation

4. SYNOPTIC ASSESSMENT • HISTORICAL VERDICT

EVALUATION & SIGNIFICANCE

IDEOLOGICAL APPEAL VS ECONOMIC DESPAIR: Nazi ideology remained essentially unchanged between 1924 and 1928, yet voters overwhelmingly rejected it (2.6%). Only when the Great Depression destroyed economic security and pushed 6 million into unemployment did Hitler's radical messianism find mass traction.	THE ROLE OF NEGATIVE COHESION: Hitler's electoral surge was fueled primarily by negative cohesion: voters united not by love of Nazi ideology, but by visceral hatred of Versailles, contempt for democratic coalition paralysis, and terrified panic over communist revolution.	THE BACKSTAIRS ABDICATION OF ELITES: Hitler did not win an electoral majority; by late 1932, Nazi support was declining. He became Chancellor because aristocratic conservative elites (Papen, Hindenburg, Meißner) actively conspired to subvert democracy, believing they could tame him.
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5. INTERACTIVE QUIZZING HUB • SCAN WITH SMARTPHONE CAMERA

20-QUESTION PRACTICE QUIZZES

KT2.1 Early Nazi Party (1919–22)  INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	KT2.2 Putsch & Lean Years  INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	KT2.3 Growth of Support (1929–32)  INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	KT2.4 Hitler Becomes Chancellor  INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ
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